Literature Review

Public Economics - Enrico Rubolino 3A ENSAE

Who Pays When Fathers Don't ? Child Support Enforcement, Single Mothers, and Debtor Responses in France

Research Question: What are the effects of automatic public intermediation of child support on payment compliance, on the economic security of creditor parents, and on the behaviour of debtor parents ?

Other related questions :

- Does switching from opt-in to default intermediation increase take-up and the regularity of payments?
- Does more secure child support income affect mothers' labour supply, their reliance on some benefits (RSA,prime d'activité, ASF), and child poverty ?
- What is the net fiscal cost of the reform, and what is its welfare value per euro spent?

Table 1: Comparison of the closest papers

Paper	**Question and mechanism**	**Setting and data**	**Identification**	**Main finding**	**Limits and relevance**
Bonnet, Garbinti & Solaz (2021), *Journal of Population Economics*	Causal effect of divorce on living standards and labour supply of each ex-spouse. Is the gender gap driven by the number of children or by within-couple earnings inequality (marital specialisation)? Role of child support and public transfers.	France. Exhaustive income and housing tax returns. Divorces and PACS dissolutions in 2009, ages 20–55 (64,393 women, 56,299 men). Living standards in 2008 vs. 2010, built in three steps: pre-transfer, with child support, with net public transfers (benefits imputed).	Difference-in-differences combined with nearest-neighbour propensity score matching on still-married couples. Exact matching within 24 strata (gender × number of children × man's earnings share), 40+ covariates including 3 years of pre-divorce earnings. Assumes no time-varying unobserved confounders. Standard errors by subsampling.	Relative to controls, women's living standard falls by 18.5%, men's by 2.1%. Within-couple earnings inequality matters far more than the number of children. Child support reduces women's loss by about 6 pp and men's gain by about 9 pp; public transfers offset the gradient in number of children. Inactive women are 29 pp more likely to (re)enter work; working women's labour income rises by 12%.	Limits: one-year horizon only; formal unions only; spousal alimony excluded; child support observed as declared paid, not as ordered, so non-payment is not identified; benefits assume 100% take-up; pre-IFPA period (2009). Relevance: benchmark for creditor-side outcomes (living standards, labour supply) on French tax data; shows that tax returns record child support on both sides, which supports matching creditors and debtors.

1 Theoretical Framework

2 Automatic Withholding and Payment Compliance

Freeman, R. B. & Waldfogel, J. (2001). « Dunning Delinquent Dads: The Effects of Child Support Enforcement Policy on Child Support Receipt by Never Married Women ». Journal of Human Resources, 36(2), 207–225

USA
Result : child support expenditures and legislation work best in tandem

Dans les années 1980 et 1990s, le nombre de familles monoparentales a augmenté. En csq, les Etats et le gvt ont augmenté les dépenses de child support enforcement.

Méthodologie : 5 sources de données qui permettent de photographier l'évolution dans les 70-90s des efforts de ces politiques pour garantir la pension alimentaire.

Résultats :

- Résultat 1 : the proportion of never married mothers receiving child support payments rose sharply, in part due to the greater national effort to dun delinquent dads.
  MAIS la part de l'ensemble des familles sans père qui reçoivent une pension reste constante ⇒ est-ce un échec de toutes ces politiques pour forcer les pères à payer ?
  Quelque chose a changé entre temps : sur la même période, la pop des mères seules se transforme : ce sont + des mères jamais mariées (et – divorcées), qui reçoivent moins souvent une pension du fait notamment que la paternité n'est pas tjr établie. Ainsi, même s'il y a du progrès, comme la population change, il y a stagnation.
  ⇒ Cf France, regarder la part des séparations de couples non mariés (concubins, pacsés) augmente par rapport aux divorces. Si quelqu'un regarde le taux global d'impayés après l'IFPA, un effet de composition similaire peut masquer l'effet de la réforme.
- Résultat 2 : les plus fortes hausses ont lieu dans les États qui ont à la fois augmenté leurs dépenses et durci leurs lois.

A. Government Efforts to Increase Child Support Payments

The laws passed in the 1970s and 1980s provided financial incentives for states to strengthen their child support enforcement efforts; they also required states to pass specific laws in the areas of wage withholding, paternity establishment, and so on.

State efforts have targeted four stages in the process of dunning delinquent dads:

1. Establishing paternity. En 1992, la paternité n'était pas établie pour les 2/3 des 1,2 Mo de naissances de femmes non mariées et 3,1 Mo d'enfants n'avaient pas de père légal.
2. Obtaining a support order : The federal government requires states to establish child support guidelines and use them in setting support orders
3. Locating the absent father. important in obtaining a support order and in enforcing one
4. Collecting money

B. The Puzzle: Increased Effort but Stable Proportions of Support

Constat : suite à ces mesures, on a davantage de support orders, davantage d'argent MAIS de 1978 à 1995, la part de mères seules jamais mariées a considérablement augmenté, passant de 20 % à 30 %.

Why has child support increased for never married women ?

Pourquoi la part des mères jamais mariées qui reçoivent une pension alimentaire a-t-elle augmenté aux États-Unis entre 1980 et 1995, de 4 % à 22 % ?

Deux hypothèses :

1. L'effort public : plus de dépenses de recouvrement et des lois plus strictes.
2. La composition : les mères jamais mariées, et leurs ex-partenaires, auraient des caractéristiques plus favorables au paiement.

Pourquoi on peut écarter l'hypothèse de composition :

- Les caractéristiques observables des mères se sont un peu améliorées : la part de diplômées du secondaire est passée d'environ 50 % à 70 % ⇒ n'explique que 2 % de la hausse des années 1980.
- Les inobservables jouent plutôt dans l'autre sens. Les pères concernés sont surtout des hommes jeunes peu qualifiés, dont la situation sur le marché du travail s'est dégradée. Cet effet aurait dû faire baisser les paiements ⇒ renforce la conclusion en faveur de l'effort public.

critiques adressées à la littérature antérieure
Les études précédentes trouvaient des résultats contradictoires, pour deux raisons :
- introduisaient chaque loi séparément, alors que les lois sont difficiles à isoler (peu de variation dans le temps et entre États) et fonctionnent ensemble ;
- traitaient dépenses et lois comme des déterminants indépendants, sans tenir compte de leurs interactions.

A. L'effet des dépenses de recouvrement

Méthodo : un modèle de probabilité linéaire où la variable expliquée vaut 1 si la mère reçoit une pension. Les régresseurs sont les caractéristiques individuelles, les dépenses de l'État par famille sans père l'année précédente, et des effets fixes État et année. Les données viennent du March CPS (1981-1995), avec des erreurs standards clusterisées.

Résultats ds tableau 2 :
- 100 $ de dépenses en plus par famille entraînent +1,4 point de taux de réception.
- Contrôler la générosité de l'aide sociale (AFDC et Food Stamps) ne change rien.
- Calcul de contribution : les dépenses ont augmenté de 276 $. Les dépenses expliqueraient donc environ 27 % de la hausse.

B. L'effet des lois

Problème : testées une par une, les 13 lois recensées (1974-1988) n'ont aucun effet cohérent.

Pk ? pour qu'une pension soit payée, il faut réussir une chaîne d'étapes :

1. établir la paternité ;
2. obtenir une décision fixant la pension ;
3. localiser le père ;
4. recouvrer l'argent.

Une loi très dure sur le recouvrement ne sert à rien si la paternité n'est pas établie ⇒ est-ce que le dispositif est complet ? ⇒ c'est plutôt cette question qui compte

Pour solutionner le design, on construit un indice synthétique (CSL index). Il est construit avec un modèle de Rasch: comme un élève qui réussit les questions rares est jugé plus compétent, un État qui a adopté les lois les plus rares est jugé plus avancé. L'indice passe de −3,29 en 1974 à 0,81 en 1988, avec un saut après les Child Support Amendments de 1984.

Résultats (tableau 3, 1981-1988) :
L'interaction entre l'indice décalé de deux ans et les dépenses est positive et significative (0,0086, à 10 %).
⇒ seules les lois adoptées 2 ans + tôt ont un effet. Les dépenses agissent vite, alors qu'une loi demande du temps : il faut créer le dispositif, former ou recruter du personnel.

COnclusion

1. L'effort public explique une part importante de la hausse des paiements aux mères jamais mariées, environ 27 % au minimum pour les seules dépenses.
2. Les lois et les moyens sont complémentaires. Des lois sans budget, ou un budget sans lois, ont peu d'effet ⇒ la combinaison fonctionne.
3. Les lois agissent avec retard (env 2 ans).

Cf projet
- l'IFPA combine règle (l'intermédiation par défaut) et moyens (l'ARIPA, qui détecte l'impayé dès le premier mois et recouvre directement). Cf la q° dans l'article : l'effet vient-il du défaut ou de la capacité de recouvrement qu'il active ?
- les étapes : en France, on retrouve la même logique, avec le titre exécutoire ⇒ l'intermédiation ⇒ recouvrement. L'IFPA n'agit qu'à partir de l'étape 2, donc rien ne change pour les parents sans titre exécutoire.
- Les délais ⇒ event-study ???

3 Responses of Paying Parents

Isaure

3.1 Rossin-Slater and Wüst (2018): Parental Responses to Child Support Obligations

Research Question The authors investigate how child support obligations affect parental behaviour following separation. Specifically, they examine whether higher mandated payments increase actual financial transfers to children and how parents adjust their custody arrangements, subsequent fertility, and labour market behaviour.

Data The study uses Danish administrative register data covering children born between 1985 and 2010, linked to their biological parents regardless of residential arrangements. The registers provide annual information on income, employment, earnings, marital and cohabitation status, educational attainment, family composition, and tax-reported child support payments.

The main analysis covers separations occurring between 1999 and 2010, with outcomes observed through 2013. The final sample contains 40,109 fathers, each linked to the mother and children. The authors restrict the sample to fathers with one or two children under 18 and separation-year gross incomes between DKK 270,000 and 405,000, expressed in 2000 prices.

A limitation is that the administrative records do not identify formal versus informal child support agreements, fully observe shared custody, or measure in-kind transfers and visits.

Identification Strategy The authors exploit quasi-exogenous variation generated by the Danish child support formula. Mandated obligations are a nonlinear step function of the father's gross income, the number of children, and the calendar year. The income thresholds and payment amounts change over time, generating differential exposure across otherwise comparable fathers.

The empirical strategy uses a **simulated instrumental variables (SIV)** approach. The potentially endogenous explanatory variable is the father's average annual child support obligation over the post-separation period, since subsequent income and fertility may themselves respond to child support obligations.

The authors instrument this variable using the statutory obligation calculated exclusively from the father's income, number of children, and applicable formula in the year of separation:

$$Z_i = g_{t_i}(I_{i,t_i}, K_{i,t_i}).$$

The first stage is:

$$\overline{Obligation}_i = \alpha + \pi Z_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}' X_i + \mathcal{F}_i + u_i,$$

and the second stage is:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \widehat{\overline{Obligation}_i} + \boldsymbol{\delta}' X_i + \mathcal{F}_i + \varepsilon_i.$$

Here, Y_i represents a post-separation outcome, X_i includes parental and child characteristics measured at separation, and $\mathcal{F}_i$ denotes fixed effects for separation year, number of children, and DKK 15,000 income bins, together with all pairwise interactions between these three dimensions. The specification also controls for the number of original children remaining under 18 in subsequent years.

Identification therefore comes from the residual variation in statutory obligations across income, family size, and separation year, conditional on their main effects and pairwise interactions. The design resembles a triple-difference strategy.

The main identifying assumption is that this residual formula-driven variation is uncorrelated with unobserved determinants of subsequent parental behaviour. The authors investigate selection into separation, balance in predetermined parental characteristics, strategic sorting around income thresholds, and pre-separation labour supply. They find no systematic evidence undermining the identifying assumption. The preferred first-stage F-statistic is approximately 94.

Main Results

- **Child support payments:** A DKK 1,000 increase in average annual mandated obligations increases observed average annual payments by only DKK 273 (significant at the 10% level). Payments therefore respond substantially less than one-for-one to higher obligations.
- **Voluntary transfers:** The probability of paying more than the mandated obligation falls by approximately 2.3 percentage points (significant at the 1% level), consistent with partial crowding out of voluntary payments.
- **Father-child co-residence:** A DKK 1,000 increase in average annual obligations reduces the probability that the father lives with his child in at least one post-separation year by approximately 1.8 percentage points (significant at the 5% level), around 6.5% relative to the sample mean.

- **Subsequent fertility:** Higher obligations increase the probability that fathers have another child while married to a new partner by approximately 1.2 percentage points (significant at the 1% level). The authors find no statistically significant effect on fathers' overall subsequent fertility or mothers' subsequent fertility.
- **Labour market outcomes:** The authors find no statistically significant effects on fathers' or mothers' labour market participation or earnings.

Interpretation and Limitations The findings suggest that child support mandates generate behavioural adjustments beyond monetary payments. Higher obligations increase observed transfers, but may crowd out voluntary financial contributions and are associated with reduced father-child co-residence. The latter is consistent with substitution between financial and non-financial parental investments, although the data cannot directly identify the underlying mechanism.

The less-than-one-for-one payment response cannot be interpreted solely as non-compliance: informal agreements, unobserved shared custody arrangements, and voluntary payments also contribute to the gap between statutory obligations and observed payments. Furthermore, the co-residence measure does not capture all forms of contact between fathers and children.

Because the sample focuses on relatively higher-income fathers, the results may not generalise to lower-income families or other institutional contexts.

Relevance for Our Research Project This paper provides an important benchmark for studying behavioural responses to child support policies using linked administrative data. It demonstrates that interventions affecting child support can influence both monetary transfers and non-monetary parental investments.

However, the policy variation differs from our proposed evaluation of France's 2022–2023 reform. Rossin-Slater and Wüst identify the effects of changes in the *amount of statutory child support obligations*, whereas the French reform changes the *administration and enforcement of payments*, without mechanically increasing the amounts owed.

Our project would therefore complement their analysis by examining whether automatic public intermediation improves actual payment compliance, the financial security of creditor parents, and potentially debtor behaviour. In particular, their results motivate investigating whether more effective payment enforcement generates behavioural responses beyond changes in financial transfers.

3.2 Cancian, Heinrich and Chung (2013): Discouraging Disadvantaged Fathers' Employment: An Unintended Consequence of Policies Designed to Support Families

Research Question The authors investigate whether child support-related debt discourages formal employment and reduces child support payments among economically disadvantaged fathers.

More specifically, they examine the causal effects of additional debt arising from Medicaid-financed childbirth expenses on fathers' subsequent formal earnings and financial contributions to their children.

The central question is whether policies intended to recover public expenditures may generate unintended labour supply responses, thereby undermining the financial support available to children.

Institutional Context The study focuses on Wisconsin, United States, where unmarried fathers may be required to reimburse childbirth expenses initially covered by Medicaid.

These birth-related obligations are imposed in addition to regular child support obligations.

For fathers with limited financial resources, such charges may create substantial debt early in the child's life.

Because child support obligations can be collected through wage withholding, additional debt may reduce the effective financial return to formal employment.

Two competing mechanisms are possible.

First, an income effect may encourage fathers to increase their labour supply to meet additional financial obligations.

Second, a substitution or discouragement effect may induce fathers to reduce formal employment when a substantial share of their earnings is subject to collection.

The direction of the response may therefore depend on fathers' previous labour market attachment.

Data The authors construct a longitudinal administrative dataset linking records from Wisconsin's child support enforcement system (KIDS) with Unemployment Insurance earnings records.

The final sample contains 8,263 fathers whose children were born between 1998 and 2003.

The monetary data cover observations between 1997 and 2005.

The analysis focuses on fathers subject to both regular child support obligations and orders to reimburse Medicaid childbirth expenses.

The baseline is defined as the first full quarter after both a positive child support obligation and a birth-cost reimbursement order are observed.

The authors follow fathers during the first two years after baseline.

The principal outcomes are annual child support payments and formal earnings reported through the Unemployment Insurance system.

The main explanatory variable is child support debt, while the identification strategy relies on typical childbirth costs assigned at the county-month level.

Descriptive statistics (Table 1):

- Average actual childbirth costs: \$2,265.
- Average typical childbirth costs: \$2,305.
- Average child support debt at baseline: \$2,370.
- Average child support debt at the beginning of the second year: \$3,018.
- Share of fathers making at least one child support payment: 77.2% in year 1 and 72.1% in year 2.
- Average annual child support payments: \$1,539 in year 1 and \$1,569 in year 2.
- Share of fathers with positive formal earnings: 74.5% in year 1 and 69.9% in year 2.
- Average annual formal earnings: \$9,256 in year 1 and \$9,613 in year 2.

These statistics illustrate the substantial financial burden of childbirth-related debt relative to fathers' earnings.

An important data limitation is that Unemployment Insurance records do not fully capture informal employment, self-employment, or unreported earnings.

Identification Strategy Endogeneity problem.

A simple regression of employment or payments on child support debt would not necessarily identify a causal effect.

Fathers with weak labour market attachment may accumulate greater debt because they have fewer resources to meet their obligations.

Conversely, higher debt may itself discourage formal employment.

This creates a potential reverse-causality problem, together with omitted-variable bias from unobserved characteristics affecting both debt and labour market outcomes.

Instrumental variables approach.

The authors exploit variation in typical Medicaid childbirth costs across Wisconsin counties and months.

These typical costs are determined by local administrative and medical charging practices, rather than directly by individual fathers' employment decisions.

They are strongly correlated with the birth-related debt assigned to fathers.

The authors therefore use typical childbirth costs as an instrument for actual child support debt.

The empirical strategy can be summarised by the following two-stage framework.

First stage:

$$D_i = \pi_0 + \pi_1 Z_{c(i),m(i)} + X_i'\pi_2 + W_{c(i)}'\pi_3 + u_i, \tag{1}$$

where D_i denotes father i's child support debt, and $Z_{c(i),m(i)}$ is the typical childbirth cost in the relevant county and month.

X_i includes individual characteristics and pre-birth labour market histories.

$W_{c(i)}$ represents county-level labour market controls, including employment shares and average earnings across industries.

The models also include county indicators and other observed characteristics.

Second stage:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_t + \beta_t \widehat{D}_i + \sum_{k=1}^{3} \gamma_{kt} E_{ik} + \sum_{k=1}^{3} \delta_{kt} \left(\widehat{D_i E_{ik}}\right) + X_i'\theta_t + W_{c(i)}'\lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{it} denotes either child support payments or formal earnings in year t after baseline.

E_{ik} identifies the father's pre-birth employment category.

The reference category consists of fathers with no formal earnings during the 7–18 months before the child's birth.

The three additional categories are:

- Employment during one to three quarters.
- Employment during all four quarters with a single employer.
- Employment during all four quarters with multiple employers.

The interaction terms allow the effect of additional debt to differ according to previous labour market attachment.

In the IV specification, both debt and its interactions with employment history are treated as endogenous.

The corresponding instruments include typical childbirth costs and their interactions with pre-birth employment categories.

The equations above are simplified representations of the authors' empirical strategy.

Identification assumptions.

The relevance condition requires typical childbirth costs to predict actual debt.

The exclusion restriction requires variation in typical childbirth costs not to affect subsequent payments or earnings through channels other than the resulting debt, conditional on controls.

This assumption would be threatened if county-month childbirth costs were correlated with unobserved local conditions directly influencing fathers' employment.

First-Stage Results The first-stage estimates confirm a strong positive relationship between typical childbirth costs and actual child support debt.

According to Appendix Table C1, a $1,000 increase in typical childbirth costs is associated with:

– A $707 increase in child support debt at baseline ($p < 0.01$).

– A $529 increase in child support debt one year after baseline ($p < 0.01$).

These estimates support the relevance of the instrumental variable.

However, a strong first stage alone does not establish the validity of the exclusion restriction.

Main Results 1. Effects on child support payments (Table 2).

The IV estimates reveal substantial heterogeneity according to fathers' pre-birth employment histories.

For fathers with no formal earnings before the child's birth, an additional $1,000 of debt is associated with:

– $126 higher annual child support payments in year 1.

– $144 higher annual child support payments in year 2.

Neither estimate is statistically significant.

For fathers with previous employment, the interaction coefficients are negative and statistically significant.

In particular, for an additional $1,000 of debt, relative to fathers with no prior employment:

– Fathers employed during one to three quarters: interaction effects of −$268 in year 1 and −$234 in year 2 (both $p < 0.01$).

– Fathers employed during all four quarters with one employer: interaction effects of −$357 in year 1 and −$374 in year 2 (both $p < 0.01$).

– Fathers employed during all four quarters with multiple employers: interaction effects of −$316 in year 1 and −$312 in year 2 (both $p < 0.01$).

Importantly, these interaction coefficients are differential effects, not total marginal effects.

For example, for fathers previously employed during all four quarters with one employer, the implied point estimate of the total effect in year 1 is:

$$126 - 357 = -231. \tag{3}$$

Thus, an additional $1,000 of instrumented debt is associated with approximately $231 less in annual child support payments for this group in year 1.

This calculation combines the main debt coefficient and the relevant interaction coefficient.

The statistical significance of the combined marginal effect cannot be inferred from the individual significance stars alone.

2. Effects on formal earnings (Table 3).

The authors also find heterogeneous effects of debt on formal earnings.

For fathers with no formal earnings before childbirth, the IV point estimates are positive:

– $240 in year 1.

– $437 in year 2.

However, these coefficients are not statistically significant.

For fathers previously employed during all four quarters with multiple employers, the interaction effects are substantially negative.

An additional $1,000 of instrumented debt is associated with differential earnings effects of:

– −$584 in year 1 ($p < 0.05$).

– −$851 in year 2 ($p < 0.05$).

For fathers previously employed during all four quarters with a single employer, the corresponding interaction effects are:

– −$436 in year 1.

– −$728 in year 2.

These latter IV interaction coefficients are not statistically significant at conventional levels.

The authors interpret the negative interactions as evidence that additional debt can discourage formal labour market activity among fathers who were previously more strongly attached to employment.

For fathers with multiple employers, the negative response may partly reflect reductions in supplementary work effort.

3. Heterogeneous responses.

The results suggest that the labour market consequences of child support debt depend on fathers' ability to adjust their working hours and earnings.

Fathers with little previous employment may respond to additional obligations by attempting to increase earnings.

By contrast, fathers already working regularly may face limited opportunities to increase labour supply.

For these fathers, the reduced effective return to additional formal earnings may generate a discouragement effect.

Interpretation and Limitations The findings suggest that additional child support debt can produce unintended effects on fathers' economic behaviour.

Rather than mechanically increasing financial transfers, larger obligations may reduce formal earnings and current child support payments among previously employed fathers.

Several limitations are important.

First, the instrumental variables strategy relies on an exclusion restriction that cannot be directly tested.

Second, the analysis measures formal earnings rather than total labour income.

Observed reductions may therefore partly reflect substitution towards informal or unreported work.

Third, the findings concern Medicaid childbirth-cost reimbursement obligations in Wisconsin, rather than ordinary changes in monthly child support amounts.

Finally, the results are heterogeneous: it would be misleading to interpret the negative interaction coefficients as evidence that all fathers reduce employment or payments when debt increases.

Relevance for Our Research Project This paper provides an important theoretical and empirical motivation for investigating debtor responses to France's 2022–2023 reform introducing automatic intermediation of child support payments.

The authors show that policies intended to improve financial support for children can generate behavioural responses among non-resident fathers.

In particular, their findings highlight the possibility that stronger collection mechanisms may affect incentives to participate in formal employment.

However, the institutional mechanism differs from the French reform.

Cancian et al. examine the effects of additional debt arising from childbirth costs, whereas automatic intermediation primarily changes how existing child support obligations are administered and collected.

Our project could therefore investigate whether improved payment collection increases the financial resources received by creditor parents without generating adverse employment responses among debtor parents.

The paper also strongly motivates an analysis of heterogeneous treatment effects by pre-reform employment history, income, and financial vulnerability.

More generally, it suggests that the success of child support policies should be evaluated not only through payment compliance but also through their potential effects on labour market behaviour and families' economic resources.

3.3 Aizer and McLanahan (2006): The Impact of Child Support Enforcement on Fertility, Parental Investments, and Child Well-Being

Research Question The authors investigate whether stronger child support enforcement (CSE) affects nonmarital fertility, parental investments, and children's health outcomes.

The central hypothesis is that stricter enforcement increases the expected financial cost of nonmarital fatherhood, thereby affecting fertility decisions.

The authors distinguish two potential channels: (i) increased financial resources available to children, and (ii) changes in the composition of parents who have children, potentially favouring parents with a greater propensity to invest in child well-being.

Institutional Context The study examines the United States, where child support enforcement was substantially strengthened during the 1980s and 1990s.

Enforcement policies include measures facilitating paternity establishment, income withholding, and the collection of child support payments.

Stronger enforcement increases the expected financial responsibility of non-resident fathers and may therefore alter incentives to have children outside marriage.

Data The main analysis uses US natality data from 1985 to 1998, based on birth certificates.

Individual birth records are aggregated into cells defined by state, year, maternal age, race, education, and marital status.

The data provide information on the number of births, maternal characteristics, prenatal care utilisation, and infant birth weight.

The authors combine these records with state-level child support enforcement expenditures, used as a measure of enforcement intensity.

The analysis includes approximately 80,000 aggregated observations, depending on the outcome.

Identification Strategy The authors exploit variation in child support enforcement expenditures across US states and over time.

A key challenge is that states with stronger enforcement may also differ in economic conditions, family policies, or social characteristics affecting fertility.

To address this issue, the authors compare changes in outcomes among unmarried women relative to married women within the same state and year.

Their empirical specification can be represented as:

$$Y_{gst} = \alpha_{st} + \beta \left(\ln(CSE_{st}) \times Single_g\right) + \gamma Single_g + X'_{gst}\delta + \varepsilon_{gst}, \tag{4}$$

where Y_{gst} denotes an outcome for demographic group g in state s and year t.

CSE_{st} measures state-level child support enforcement expenditures, while $Single_g$ indicates unmarried mothers.

The term α_{st} represents state-by-year fixed effects, which absorb shocks common to married and unmarried women within each state-year.

X_{gst} includes demographic controls, such as maternal age, education, and race.

The coefficient of interest, β, captures the differential association between enforcement intensity and outcomes for unmarried mothers, relative to married mothers.

For fertility outcomes, the dependent variable is the logarithm of the number of births. For prenatal investments and birth outcomes, the authors use measures of prenatal care and low birth weight.

Identification relies on the assumption that unobserved factors correlated with enforcement do not differentially affect unmarried and married women within the same state-year.

Main Results

- **Nonmarital fertility:** The estimated coefficient on the interaction between log enforcement expenditures and unmarried status is -0.033 (Table 1).
  This implies that a 10% increase in enforcement expenditures is associated with an approximately 0.33% decline in births to unmarried women relative to married women.
- **Early prenatal care:** The estimated coefficient for initiation of prenatal care during the first trimester is 0.01847 (Table 2).
  The authors estimate that increased enforcement accounts for approximately 50% of the observed improvement in early prenatal care among unmarried mothers over the study period.
- **Number of prenatal visits:** The estimated coefficient is 0.08071 (Table 2).
  The authors attribute approximately 6% of the observed increase in prenatal visits among unmarried mothers to stronger enforcement.
- **Low birth weight:** The estimated coefficient is -0.00154 (Table 2).
  The authors estimate that stronger enforcement explains approximately 13% of the observed decline in low birth weight among children born to unmarried mothers.
- **Selection into parenthood:** The results are consistent with stronger enforcement changing the composition of nonmarital births, with relatively greater representation of more educated mothers and mothers with a higher propensity to invest in children.

Interpretation and Limitations The findings suggest that stronger child support enforcement affects family outcomes through both financial incentives and selection into parenthood.

By increasing the expected cost of nonmarital fatherhood, stricter enforcement may discourage some nonmarital births.

Changes in the composition of parents may subsequently influence prenatal investments and infant health outcomes.

However, the estimated improvements in prenatal care and birth outcomes cannot be interpreted exclusively as behavioural changes among a fixed population of mothers.

Part of the observed improvement may reflect changes in which women become mothers.

Furthermore, enforcement intensity is measured using state-level expenditures rather than individual payment compliance.

The estimates therefore capture the effects associated with broader enforcement intensity, not the isolated effect of a specific payment collection mechanism.

Relevance for Our Research Project This paper is particularly relevant to our evaluation of France's 2022–2023 reform introducing automatic intermediation of child support payments.

Unlike studies focusing on changes in the statutory amount of child support obligations, Aizer and McLanahan investigate the effects of stronger enforcement.

Their findings demonstrate that enforcement policies may influence outcomes beyond the financial transfers received by custodial parents.

However, their analysis primarily concerns fertility decisions, prenatal investments, and selection into parenthood.

Our proposed project instead focuses on families with existing child support obligations and evaluates a reform changing the administration and collection of payments.

Our contribution would therefore be to examine whether automatic intermediation improves actual payment compliance and the financial security of creditor parents, while also investigating potential behavioural responses among debtor parents.

The paper highlights the importance of distinguishing direct financial effects from broader behavioural and compositional effects of child support policies.

4 Receiving Mothers: Labor Supply, Benefits, and Living Standards

4.1 C. Bonnet, B. Garbinti, A. Solaz, "The Flip Side of Marital Specialization: The Gendered Effect of Divorce on Living Standards and Labor Supply", Journal of Population Economics, 2021

Motivation Divorce hurts women more than men. In prior studies, women's living standards fall by 10–40%, while men's stay stable or rise. The usual explanation is **custody**: mothers bear the cost of raising the children. The authors argue this is only part of the story. Theory (Cigno 2012; Lafortune & Low 2019) treats marriage as a commitment device. It lets one spouse specialize in home production in exchange for compensation. If that compensation is insufficient at divorce, the cost of specialization shows up. Existing evidence has three weaknesses:

- It mostly compares the same people before and after divorce, which is not causal.
- It relies on small survey samples with non-random attrition.
- It often observes only one side of child support (paid or received, not both).

Research question What is the causal effect of divorce on each ex-spouse's living standard and labor supply? And is the gender gap driven mainly by the number of children or by within-couple earnings inequality, used as a proxy for marital specialization?

Data and design Data: exhaustive French income-tax and housing-tax returns. The sample covers couples who divorced or dissolved a PACS in 2009, aged 20–55: about 64k women and 56k men.

Outcome: living standard in 2008 vs 2010, built in three steps:

- pre-transfer income,
- plus child support,
- plus net public transfers (benefits are imputed).

Method: difference-in-differences combined with nearest-neighbor propensity score matching. Matching is done separately in 24 groups defined by gender × number of children × the man's share of couple earnings. It uses more than 40 covariates, including earnings in each of the 3 years before divorce.

Contributions **Data**: both ex-partners are observed, with child support both paid and received. Attrition is 7% and is reweighted.
Causal estimates: women lose 19% (vs –14% before–after). For men, the sign flips to –2% (vs +3.5% before–after).
Mechanism: An accounting decomposition (eq. 1–2) and the regressions both show that within-couple earnings inequality matters far more than the number of children. The second earner loses regardless of gender. Men who earned less than 40% of couple earnings lose about 20%.
Role of transfers: Public transfers remove the link between number of children and women's losses. Child support raises women's living standard by about 6 percentage points and reduces men's gain by about 9 points.
Labor supply: Previously inactive women are 29 percentage points more likely to enter work than their matched controls. Working women's labor income rises by 12%. Divorced men face about a 40% higher risk of unemployment.
Robustness: results hold for medians, alternative equivalence scales, PACS dissolutions and the repartnered sample. Repartnering largely offsets the losses.

5 Guaranteed Maintenance, Tax-Benefit Interactions, and Default Effects

6 French Institutional Sources

HCFEA (Conseil de la famille / Conseil de l'enfance et de l'adolescence) (2025). « Note sur l'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires ». Haut Conseil de la famille, de l'enfance et de l'âge

État des lieux du déploiement de la réforme du service public de l'Intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires (Ifpa)

Vocabulaire :

- CEEE : contribution à l'entretien et à l'éducation de l'enfant : nom juridique pour désigner la pension alimentaire. Somme que le parent débiteur verse au parent créancier (avec qui habite l'enfant)
- ARIPA : Agence de recouvrement et d'intermédiation des pensions alimentaires : c'est l'organisme. Initialement, elle servait à recouvrer les impayés, et maintenant elle fait l'intermédiaire (nouveau).
- IFPA : service (différent de l'organisme) : ainsi, le parent débiteur, au lieu de verser directement l'argent au parent créancier, le verse à l'ARIPA chaque mois
- ASF (allocation de soutien familial) : prestation versée par la CAF au créancier d'environ 200 € par enfant. Intervient dans 3 cas : 1. si le débiteur ne paie pas 2. La pension est inférieure au montant de l'ASF (allocation pour compléter) 3. Pas de pension fixé ou parent absent. Si le parent ne paie pas, l'Aripa lance le recouvrement auprès du débiteur (amiable ou forcé).

Ifpa introduite en 2017 d'abord seulement dans le cas de violences conjugales ou familiales avant d'être étendue progressivement :

- A tous les cas dans lesquels un des parents en fait la demande (opt-in)
- Puis tous les divorces / séparations SAUF lorsque les 2 parents s'y opposent (opt-out).

Mais plusieurs choses empêchent portée effective de l'Ifpa :

- Problème d'application de l'Ifpa, qui est ainsi réservé aux divorces prononcés par décision judiciare et séparations de non-mariés
- l'Ifpa ne s'applique pas lorsque le débiteur d'aliments est reconnu comme « hors d'état » de se soumettre à ses obligations ⇒ pour les violences conjugales, l'Ifpa est obligatoire depuis 2022

De plus, l'Ifpa concerne que les sommes dues au titre de la contribution à l'entretien et à l'éducation de l'enfant (CEEE). On pourrait imaginer qu'elle s'applique également aux sommes dues au titre des prestations compensatoires lorsque celles-ci sont versées sous forme de rentes.

Difficultés de fonctionnement quand l'Ifpa est mise en place :

- retards dans le versement de l'ASF (allocation de soutien familial) en cas d'impayé
- prévoir par décret solution sur les modalités de règlement de la pension

Pb : l'information relative aux séparations (nombre intervenant chaque année) et aux situations d'impayés de pensions alimentaires (fréquence des situations d'impayé, nombre de titres exécutoires délivrés ne donnant pas lieu à Ifpa, etc.) est lacunaire. Pour être réellement en capacité de mesurer l'efficacité du dispositif, il conviendrait d'améliorer le système de remontée d'informations.

I. Etat des lieux du service public de l'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires

Déploiement progressif Le champ d'application du nouveau service de l'Ifpa a été progressivement étendu au-delà des situations de violences conjugales :

- à compter du 1er octobre 2020, l'intermédiation financière est accessible sur demande de l'un des parents auprès de l'Aripa à la suite d'un impayé de pension alimentaire (indépendamment de toute situation de violence) ;
- à compter du 1er janvier 2021, levée de la condition de l'impayé : le service est étendu à tous les parents divorcés ou séparés qui en font la demande ;
- à compter du 1er mars 2022, levée de la condition de demande : le service est systématisé, sans demande, pour tous les parents qui divorcent ;
- à compter du 1er janvier 2023, extension aux parents séparés hors divorce : le service devient systématique, sans demande pour tous les parents qui se séparent, y compris les parents non mariés (ex-concubins et ex-pacsés).

Conditions d'application de l'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires Actuellement, les sommes dues au titre des prestations compensatoires ne sont pas concernées par l'Ifpa (les prestations compensatoires servent à pallier la différence de niveau de vie qu'un divorce crée entre des époux).

L'Ifpa est applicable sur l'ensemble du territoire français SAUF Mayotte, saint pierre et miquelon, polynésie française...

Condition : disposer d'un titre exécutoire (l'acte juridique qui fixe le montant de la CEEE versée sous la forme d'une pension alimentaire) fourni par le parent créancier pour bénéficier du service d'intermédiation. Ce document permet de forcer l'exécution d'une obligation (plusieurs documents valent ce titre exécutoire : un jugement du juge, une convention de divorce, une convention homologuée par le juge, un document délivré par la CAF...).

Pour pouvoir bénéficier du service de l'Ifpa, le parent créancier doit remplir la condition de stabilité de résidence sur le territoire français et de régularité du séjour. Le parent débiteur, lui, doit remplir la condition de stabilité de résidence.

⇒ Le parent débiteur ne doit pas être hors d'état. Ces situations de hors d'état, qui se traduisent par des ASF non recouvrables, concernent, selon les données fournies par la Cnaf, 30 % des enfants bénéficiaires de l'ASF. Une ASF non recouvrable signifie que la CAF verse l'ASF au créancier sans chercher à se faire rembourser.

Modalités de mise en œuvre

- Principe de l'automaticité de l'intermédiation pour les divorces ayant eu lieu après mars 2022 et pour les séparations ayant eu lieu après 2023 (avec deux exceptions)
- Intermédiation sur demande pour les divorces ayant eu lieu avant mars 2022 et les séparations ayant eu lieu avant 2023 et pour les cas où elle n'a pas été initialement mise en place
- Intermédiation obligatoire sur décision du juge en cas de violences conjugales

Pb : Les avocats et notaires ne transmettent pas nécessairement les titres exécutoires ⇒ il faudrait rendre cette transmission automatique et obligatoire (cette transmission n'est pas encouragée par les acteurs au vu du faible nombre de titres exécutoires fournis par les avocats et notaires).

La demande d'intermédiation financière, lorsqu'elle est demandée par les usagers, l'est principalement en raison d'un impayé de pension.

⇒ Le caractère préventif de l'intermédiation voulue par le législateur en est affaibli.

Problème 2 : la coexistence de 2 barèmes de fixation des pensions alimentaires, l'un propre à la justice, l'autre propre à l'Aripa (cf titre exécutoire évoqué plus haut, produit par la CAF dans les séparations non judiciaires) ⇒ rend le dispositif complexe, et le recours aux titres exécutoires de la CAF plus faible : le barème qu'elle utilise conduit pour les trois-quarts des parents débiteurs à des montants de CEEE plus élevés que la table de référence indicative mise à disposition des juges aux affaires familiales (JAF) par le ministère de la Justice en avril 2010.

Les modalités de versement de la pension alimentaire Le parent débiteur d'une pension verse le montant à un tiers (l'ODPF, qui est dans la plupart des cas la CAF) qui reverse au parent créancier. Si impayé, l'ODPF informe le parent débiteur de régulariser sa situation sous 15 jours. Sinon, procédure de recouvrement forcé.

2 façons de prélever :

- Prélèvement automatique (64 % des cas)
- Ou versée directement par le débiteur à l'organisme, qui reverse au parent créancier.

MAIS PROBLEME : en cas de survenue d'un impayé dans le cadre d'une Ifpa, les parcours se complexifient et perdent en lisibilité pour le parent créancier, car, pour bénéficier du versement temporaire de l'ASF recouvrable, il doit en faire la demande lui-même.

Les modalités de revalorisation et de révision de la CEEE La pension alimentaire peut aussi être révisée pour tenir compte de l'évolution des besoins de l'enfant et des revenus de chacun des deux parents. AU moment du rapport, pas possible de demander à l'Aripa la révision d'une pension si celle-ci a été fixée par le juge.

Premiers résultats du service public d'intermédiation financière

Le taux de recours au service Forte progression depuis 2020. A mettre en lien avec nombre de divorces et séparations avec enfants donnant lieu à pension alimentaire suscpetible d'être intermédiée MAIS ce chiffre n'est pas connu.

Perception du dispositif par les usagers

- Simplicité des démarches
- Effets positifs pour les mères avec une amélioration de leur situation financière et matérielle, une atténuation de leur charge mentale et une plus grande légitimation de la pension comme droit

MAIS la Cour des comptes note un taux d'abandon important : 15 % des parents renoncent à l'intermédiation financière après en avoir demandé le bénéfice